

Real Estate English

Participant workbook: agency, fair housing, pricing, offers, disclosures, inspections, financing, closing, leasing, and transaction dialogue practice

Audience: advanced ESL learners working in real estate, leasing, property management, commercial real estate, transaction coordination, and related roles

Focus: high-level professional English for real estate workplaces, including agency, representation agreements, buyer and seller consultations, pricing, property descriptions, fair housing, offers, contingencies, inspections, appraisals, financing, disclosures, title, escrow, closings, leasing, commercial basics, and realistic transaction dialogue.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who work as agents, brokers, assistants, transaction coordinators, property managers, leasing staff, commercial real estate staff, relocation specialists, mortgage-adjacent staff, title-adjacent staff, or real-estate business partners.

Teaching stance: real estate English is trust, precision, and risk control under time pressure. Learners need language that is persuasive but not misleading, helpful but not discriminatory, confident but not legally careless. This curriculum teaches professional communication and judgment, not state-specific legal advice.

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook helps you sound precise, calm, and trustworthy in real estate conversations. The goal is not to memorize more terms. The goal is to explain role, evidence, risk, options, and next steps in a way clients and colleagues can act on.

Your starting point

- Which real estate conversations are hardest for you: buyer intake, listing price, fair housing questions, offer strategy, inspections, financing updates, leasing, or conflict?
- Which terms do you understand when reading but avoid when speaking?
- When a client asks a risky question, do you become too agreeable, too blunt, too vague, or too legalistic?
- What is one recent transaction conversation you wish you had handled more clearly?

Use the guided dialogue activities below. Every item has four choices and a rationale in the answer key; no open-ended writing is required.

Real Estate Workstream Language

Area	Useful verbs	Example sentence
Agency	represent, disclose, consent, document, refer	Before we tour, we need to clarify representation and compensation.
Search	prioritize, filter, compare, verify, narrow	Let's turn your preferences into objective search criteria.
Pricing	compare, adjust, justify, test, reposition	The price needs support from relevant comps and current competition.
Offers	structure, counter, waive, protect, negotiate	This term may strengthen the offer, but it increases your risk.
Transaction	coordinate, confirm, escalate, update, close	The open item is lender documentation, and the next update is due tomorrow.
Risk	disclose, document, pause, review, comply	We should route that question to broker or legal review before responding.

Practice Pages

Module 1. Agency, Representation, Compensation, and Trust

Real estate professionals need language for who they represent, what duties they owe, how compensation works, and what the client is agreeing to before advice becomes transaction-critical.

What you should be able to do

- Distinguish client, customer, agency, fiduciary duty, representation agreement, listing agreement, buyer agreement, dual agency, designated agency, and transaction brokerage.
- Explain written buyer agreements and compensation language without sounding defensive or evasive.
- Clarify when a professional can advise, when they must disclose, and when they should refer to legal, tax, lending, or inspection experts.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A buyer wants to see a house immediately but has not discussed representation or compensation.

Speaker	Line
Buyer	Can you show me the house this afternoon? I do not want to sign anything yet.
Agent	I understand. Before I tour property with you as your agent, we need a written agreement that explains my services, the term, and how compensation works.
ESL learner	This agreement is not meant to pressure you. It defines who I represent, what I can do for you, and what compensation we agree to. We can keep the term narrow if you only want to evaluate this property.
Buyer	So I have to pay you?
ESL learner	Compensation is negotiable and may be paid in different ways depending on the offer and transaction. The important point is that we discuss it clearly before we start _____.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	mitigation
B	approval
C	control
D	representation

Module 2. Client Intake, Needs Analysis, and Property Search

Good real estate conversations move from emotion to criteria: budget, timeline, location needs, property type, financing readiness, risk tolerance, and decision process.

What you should be able to do

- Ask precise intake questions without sounding intrusive or robotic.
- Separate must-haves, nice-to-haves, deal breakers, assumptions, and tradeoffs.
- Respond to neighborhood, school, safety, and demographic questions with fair-housing-safe language and objective resources.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A buyer asks for subjective neighborhood advice that could lead to steering.

Speaker	Line
Buyer	Is this a good neighborhood for families like us?
Agent	I can help you compare objective information, but I cannot steer you based on who lives here.
ESL learner	Let's define what 'good' means for you: commute time, budget, property condition, parks, school district boundaries, noise, transit, or walkability. I can point you to public resources so you can evaluate the area using your own priorities.
Buyer	But would you live here?
ESL learner	I should not substitute my personal preference for your decision. I can give you property facts and objective sources, and you can decide _____ the area fits your needs.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	owner
B	whether
C	evidence
D	risk

Module 3. Listings, Property Descriptions, Pricing, and Market Data

Listing and pricing language must be attractive, accurate, objective, and defensible. Learners need to discuss comps, condition, market movement, and seller expectations without overpromising.

What you should be able to do

- Use CMA, comp, active, pending, closed, DOM, concessions, list-to-sale ratio, appraisal, and absorption terminology accurately.
- Explain pricing strategy to a seller who wants a number above market evidence.
- Write property descriptions that highlight property features without discriminatory implications or unsupported claims.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A seller wants to list far above the CMA range because a neighbor got a high price last year.

Speaker	Line
Seller	My neighbor sold for more last year. I want to list at that number plus 10 percent.
Listing agent	The market has changed since then.
ESL learner	We can test a premium only if the evidence supports it. The closest recent comps show lower closed prices, longer DOM, and seller concessions. If we list too high, we may reduce urgency and help competing listings look more attractive.
Seller	I do not want to leave money on the table.
ESL learner	Neither do I. My recommendation is a price that creates serious buyer activity and gives us leverage. We can also agree now on a review point if showings or _____ are weak.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	control
B	feedback
C	mitigation
D	approval

Module 4. Showings, Open Houses, Fair Housing, and Advertising

Showings and advertising create high-risk language moments. Real estate professionals must be warm, informative, and useful without steering, discriminating, or making claims they cannot support.

What you should be able to do

- Respond to questions about neighborhood, schools, crime, demographics, religion, families, disability access, and safety with appropriate objective-resource language.
- Explain fair housing concepts such as protected class, steering, redlining, blockbusting, reasonable accommodation, and discriminatory advertising.
- Handle open-house conversations with represented buyers, unrepresented buyers, and visitors who ask for advice outside the professional's role.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A buyer wants to win in a competitive situation but does not understand the risk of waiving protections.

Speaker	Line
Buyer	Let's waive everything and offer over asking.
Agent	That may strengthen the offer, but it changes your risk.
ESL learner	We should compare price, appraisal gap, inspection rights, financing contingency, earnest money, closing date, and seller priorities. A stronger offer is not just a higher price. It is also certainty and clean terms.
Buyer	Can we waive inspection?
ESL learner	You can choose that strategy, but I want you to understand the _____. Another option is a shorter inspection period, informational inspection, or cap on repair requests, depending on local practice and your comfort level.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	risk
B	scope
C	timeline
D	assumption

Module 5. Offers, Counteroffers, Negotiation, and Contingencies

Offer strategy requires precise language around price, financing, earnest money, contingencies, timelines, concessions, appraisal risk, inspection risk, and seller priorities.

What you should be able to do

- Use offer terminology accurately: earnest money, contingency, counteroffer, escalation clause, appraisal gap, seller concession, backup offer, possession, and rent-back.
- Explain tradeoffs between competitiveness and protection.
- Summarize competing offers without exaggeration, unauthorized disclosure, or pressure language.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

An inspection found roof and electrical issues. The buyer is angry and wants the seller to fix everything.

Speaker	Line
Buyer	This house has problems. Ask them to fix every item.
Agent	We need to separate major issues from normal maintenance.
ESL learner	The strongest request will focus on safety, systems, and cost. Instead of sending a long emotional list, we can ask for a licensed electrician to address the panel issue and request a credit toward the roof repair, supported by the inspection report and estimate.
Buyer	What if they refuse?
ESL learner	Then we evaluate your contract options, your appetite for repairs, and whether a revised price or credit makes the _____ acceptable.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	timeline
B	assumption
C	mitigation
D	risk

Module 6. Inspections, Repairs, Disclosures, and Due Diligence

After contract, language becomes tense. Learners need to discuss defects, repair requests, seller disclosures, inspection scope, specialist referrals, and deal uncertainty without blame or panic.

What you should be able to do

- Discuss inspection findings, material defects, seller disclosure, lead-based paint, property condition, repair requests, credits, and due diligence periods.
- Separate factual observation, expert opinion, negotiation strategy, and legal advice.
- Write repair-request and disclosure follow-up language that is clear, calm, and documented.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

The appraisal comes in below contract price and financing is affected.

Speaker	Line
Lender	The appraisal is twenty thousand below contract price.
Buyer	Does that mean the deal is dead?
ESL learner	Not automatically. We have several paths: challenge the appraisal if there are factual issues, renegotiate price, increase down payment, use an appraisal-gap clause if one exists, or cancel if the contract allows it.
Buyer	What should we do?
ESL learner	First, let's review the appraisal with the lender and compare it to our comps. Then we can choose a negotiation position based on your cash, contract rights, and _____ tolerance.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	evidence
B	risk
C	control
D	disclosure

Module 7. Financing, Appraisal, Title, Escrow, and Closing

Closings depend on many parties and documents. Learners need language for mortgage status, underwriting conditions, Loan Estimate, Closing Disclosure, title issues, escrow, prorations, walk-through, and closing delays.

What you should be able to do

- Explain pre-approval, proof of funds, underwriting, conditional approval, clear to close, appraisal, title search, lien, escrow, prorations, Loan Estimate, Closing Disclosure, and cash to close.
- Coordinate updates among buyer, seller, lender, title, escrow, attorney, inspector, and brokerage without overstepping.
- Handle closing delays with timelines, owners, dependencies, and next steps.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

Closing is approaching but the lender still needs documentation.

Speaker	Line
Seller agent	Are your buyers clear to close? We need certainty.
Buyer agent	The file is still in underwriting.
ESL learner	The lender has issued conditional approval and is waiting on two documents from the buyer. We expect an update tomorrow afternoon. I do not want to overpromise, so I will send a written status update by 4 p.m. with any impact on closing.
Seller agent	Should we issue a notice?
ESL learner	I understand your concern. Please send any contract notice through the proper channel. Meanwhile, I will keep the timeline, _____, and dependency clear for everyone.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	timeline
B	assumption
C	owner
D	scope

Module 8. Leasing, Property Management, Commercial Basics, Ethics, and Crisis Scenarios

Real estate English is broader than residential sales. Learners need enough language for leases, screening, property management, commercial terms, referral boundaries, complaints, and reputational risk.

What you should be able to do

- Use leasing and commercial terms such as lease term, security deposit, rent roll, CAM, NNN, NOI, cap rate, LOI, TI allowance, estoppel, and operating expenses.
- Discuss tenant screening, reasonable accommodation, habitability, maintenance, rent collection, and lease enforcement with fairness and documentation.
- Respond to ethical pressure, referral-kickback risk, public complaints, and transaction breakdowns with documented, policy-aware language.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A settlement-service provider offers valuable benefits for referrals.

Speaker	Line
Vendor	If you send us your buyers, we can sponsor your client event and give you premium tickets.
Agent	That sounds generous, but we need to be careful.
ESL learner	I cannot accept anything of value in exchange for settlement-service referrals. If we discuss marketing or sponsorship, it must be reviewed by the broker and compliance, tied to real services, and not conditioned on referrals.
Vendor	Everyone does it.
ESL learner	Our policy is to protect clients and avoid referral-kickback _____. I can share your public information with clients if they ask for options, but I cannot trade referrals for benefits.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	mitigation
B	approval
C	control
D	risk

Phrase Bank

Agency and role clarity

- Before I advise you as a client, we need to clarify representation and compensation.
- My role is to explain the process and market context; legal interpretation should come from your attorney.
- This agreement defines the services, term, compensation, and termination process.
- Because the relationship could create a conflict, we need clear disclosure and informed consent before proceeding.

Fair housing and objective resources

- I cannot steer you based on who lives in an area, but I can help you compare objective criteria.
- Let's define what matters to you: commute, schools, budget, property condition, noise, transit, or amenities.
- I can direct you to public resources so you can make your own neighborhood assessment.
- The safest description focuses on property features, not the type of person who might live there.

Pricing and market data

- The strongest price recommendation is the one we can defend with relevant comps.
- If we list above the evidence, we should agree now on a review point and adjustment plan.
- Active listings show competition; closed sales show what buyers actually paid.
- A premium price needs premium evidence: condition, location, scarcity, upgrades, or buyer demand.

Offer and negotiation

- A stronger offer is not only higher price; it is also certainty, timing, and cleaner terms.
- Waiving a contingency may make the offer more competitive, but it also changes your risk.
- Let's separate what we want, what we can support, and what we are willing to risk.
- I recommend we put the request in specific, document-supported terms.

Transaction coordination

- Here is the current status, the open item, the owner, and the deadline.
- I do not want to overpromise; I will confirm in writing once the lender updates us.
- This issue may affect closing timing, so I am escalating it now.
- Let's keep communication factual and avoid assigning blame before we know the cause.

Risk and ethics

- I cannot accept anything of value in exchange for referrals.
- If we know a material issue, hiding it creates more risk than documenting it.
- Let's pause and route this through the broker or compliance before responding.
- The client should understand the consequence before signing or waiving that term.

Answer Key and Rationale

Check each answer after completing the dialogue. The rationale shows why the correct phrase is the strongest fit for the real workplace situation.

1. Buyer Consultation: Agreement Before Touring

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. representation	'representation' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

2. Fair Housing Question: 'Is This a Good Neighborhood?'

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. whether	'whether' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

3. Listing Presentation: Seller Wants an Unrealistic Price

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. feedback	'feedback' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

4. Multiple Offers: Stronger Terms vs Higher Price

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

5. Inspection Negotiation: Repair Credit

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

6. Low Appraisal: Contract Price Is Higher Than Appraised Value

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

7. Financing Delay: Underwriting Conditions

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. owner	'owner' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

8. RESPA Risk: Referral Benefit

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.